The Compass or the Filter: Redefining the Purpose of Assessment

Assessments should be more than just a hurdle to clear; they should be a compass for both the teacher and the learner. In Marie Paz Morales' research, we see a shift from testing as a final verdict to testing as a diagnostic tool. By focusing on "distracter analysis"—the study of why students choose specific wrong answers—the test becomes a way to "reach a hand" to students, identifying precise conceptual gaps. This approach transforms a cold, multiple-choice sheet into a conversation about where a student is struggling and how a teacher can help them find their footing.

This methodology stands in stark contrast to my experience at Parañaque Science High School. In that high-pressure environment, we were tested almost weekly, and failing was treated as an inevitable norm of "excellence." While the rigor forced us to be intimate with our textbooks, the atmosphere was far from holistic. We were expected to be the best in the city, yet we were drowning in expectations. Because our exams were used only to rank us rather than to diagnose our needs, we lost our confidence. We weren't being taught; we were being filtered.

To foster true learning, we must synthesize academic rigor with an encouraging atmosphere. The journal article proves that we can maintain high standards—focusing on higher-order thinking skills—without leaving students behind. By adopting a "diagnostic mindset," educators can turn a failed quiz from a source of shame into a roadmap for growth. At the end of the day, the goal of education shouldn't be to see who survives the deep end, but to ensure every student has the tools and the confidence to swim.